

Robert Clay Grubbs
Nathan Wainstein
EAE 4900-006
May 1, 2023

Abstraction and Defamiliarization:
Tender Buttons and Please, Touch the Artwork

When a text becomes difficult to interpret, it can quickly make a reader question how they were supposed to draw meaning from it in the first place. Through this kind of obscurity, the book *Tender Buttons* and the game *Please, Touch the Artwork* effectively shift focus onto how they, and other works in their medium, are understood. *Tender Buttons* begins its particularly confusing section “Rooms” by providing a sort of hint for how one might make sense of it, as well as a place to start, a noun. “Act so that there is no use in a center” (Stein, 63). The first, vague verb, “act,” is this hint. Considering how the sentence seems to lack a clear denotation, one way to “act” might be to examine the other, still vague, words given to the reader. After this imperative, “act”, “Rooms” provides the noun, “center”, and attribute of it, “no use”. The reader can then partially define a center as useless. The meaning of the word “center” is still loose and somewhat vacant, but there’s an outline and it now better informs the reader’s understanding of *how* to act. By going through the process of slowly tracing words and layering them on each other, the entire first sentence of “Rooms” acquires a clearer meaning. “No” combines with “use”, “no use” interacts with “center”, and a useless center defines how “Rooms” wants us to “act”. To understand a text in this way, the reader relies almost entirely on the relations *between* words rather than their individual meaning. A “center” is de-centered and only understood through the other words surrounding it, rather than by an external definition. This process is quickly necessitated by the abstraction of these words, where signification often drifts away from literality and representation.

The abstraction of English in *Tender Buttons* is particularly challenging given its love for simple and frequently used words. Rather than generating difficulty from unknown phrases or references, the challenge of comprehension in *Tender Buttons* would be more aptly described as when a work or artist is “obscure in order to achieve certain specific stylistic effects”; this is what George Steiner defines as tactical difficulty (270). A core component of this form of difficulty is the “creation of new words and syntactic modes” that force the reader to “learn the language” of the text (Steiner, 270). A challenge like this clearly resonates with the style of *Tender Buttons*, since Stein’s language often creates new words and meanings with the body of well-known ones. While reading “Rooms”, the word “center” morphs from its literal spatial metric into a connotative entity. It becomes detached from our previous use of it in English, our center of its meaning. Once centers have been established to have no use, this definition is only reinforced when other objects are given contrasting affordances, like the fact that “no windows are useless” (Stein, 66). Looking at the juxtaposition of useless centers in a room with useful windows constructs an environment, or set of abstract ideas with clear relations. “Room”’s new language begins to reveal itself to the reader through these distinctions; to act so that there is no use in a center could be to turn towards the now useful window. Readers, through abstraction, are restricted from bringing their previously defined center of meaning into the text. Thus, they are forced to construct a new reality, but only with the relations *Tender Buttons* provides.

This way in which “Rooms” plays with the relational properties of language is closely in-line with the ludic aesthetics of color placement in *Please, Touch the Artwork*’s section, “The Style”. *Please, Touch the Artwork* is a short puzzle game that allows the player to interact with the artwork of Piet Mondrian through various mini-games inspired by his approaches to abstraction. This section of the game relies on sequential puzzles where the player must recreate

arrangements of red, yellow, and blue based on his iconic compositions. The UI provides the model composition on the left of the screen and a hand that tracks the player's mouse to facilitate their interactions with a blank canvas on the right. The player has to touch their canvas on the right with this hand, draw lines, and fill in colors to recreate the left composition in as few moves as possible (see fig.1). When it comes to drawing lines, this mechanic is fairly intuitive since the stand-in hand feels like a natural way to click and place anything on the canvas. This all changes, however, when the player has to apply color. The lines drawn create divisions and planes, and the player fills in those new planes with colors, but this mechanic functions differently to how lines

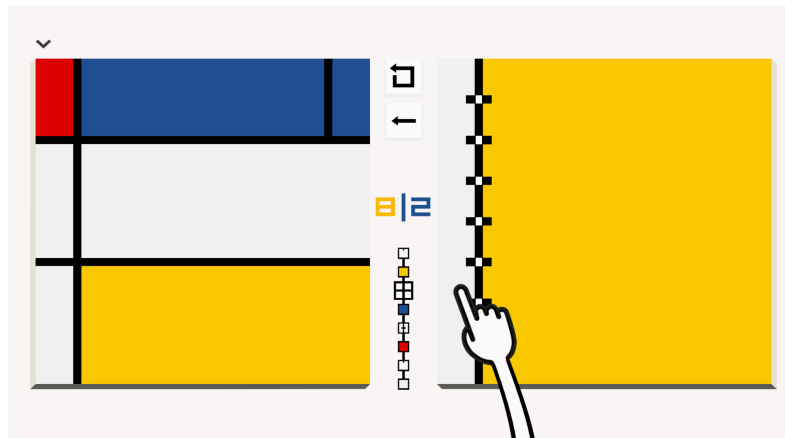


Fig. 1. Personal Screenshot of Composition 45 from *Please, Touch the Artwork*.

are placed. While the hand seems to imply that the player is going to interact with whatever is being touched, the coloring mechanic only affects its neighboring planes. The plane that's touched remains unaffected, necessitating relational rather than isolated thought; which is similar to how *Tender Buttons* requires the reader to examine words in reference to its own specific structure, rather than their original definitions. In both of these cases, whatever a reader or player might want to focus on is especially meaningless without immediate context. "Rooms"'s concept

of a “center” is literalized through play in “The Style”; the actual center point of interaction can’t matter, only its surrounding divisions do, like windows in a room.

The similarities between these two texts make a lot of sense considering that “The Style”’s form of challenge also mirrors *Tender Button*’s tactical difficulty. At first glance, *Please, Touch the Artwork*’s coloring mechanic exhibits a mechanical difficulty, what Patrick Jagoda defines as “deliberately awkward controls” (205). It’s quite strange and unintuitive for a game’s control scheme to alter everything *around* what the player selects, but not what they actually click on. Though “The Style” only pushes this peculiar mechanic further. The interactive unease that manifests from it becomes even more intense in the finale of the sequence: Compositions 55 through 58. These puzzles remove the lines that facilitate player awareness like they were just



Fig. 2. Personal Screenshot of Composition 56 from *Please, Touch the Artwork*.

training wheels (see fig.2). Up until this point, the player can mostly understand how to interact with the puzzle. They can make out which planes will be affected by which input, but clicking on this now utterly blank canvas colors in planes that the player *can't* directly perceive. There is no longer a “center” for the player to even consider, just approximate locations on the canvas that color in weird inorganic shapes. During these puzzles, the challenge transcends mechanical and

reaches interpretive difficulty: a type of difficulty in games that involves the “everyday processes of meaning making” and making sense of things (Jagoda, 212).

In order for a player to know what a given mechanic does and feel motivated to act, they have to be able to interpret its dynamics and effects. Cardona et al. finds with their MDA-GFI model that a given gamestate is “presented to the player via Feedback that the Player observes and interprets” (10). This interpretation then leads to a clearer internalization of the player’s goals that “motivate which tasks they end up pursuing” and these tasks are carried out by the player “articulating them through the game’s afforded Mechanics” (Cardona et al., 10). In short, how a player *interprets* their given game state and affordances directly affects how they enact a *mechanic*. In the case of Compositions 55 through 58, challenge doesn’t only stem from the awkward mechanical difficulty inherent in the strange controls. It also comes from the minimal feedback describing where the planes are, creating interpretive difficulty and insecurity when the player enacts a mechanic. The player is unable to easily make sense of the game space and take clear meaning from it. Instead, they’re forced to deal with difficulty that manifests before even engaging with the text.

Jagoda’s description of interpretive difficulty is actually a little loose and borrows a fair amount from Steiner’s typology of difficulty to help describe it (Jagoda, 212). In that case, the sense of interpretive difficulty that these compositions most closely align with is certainly Steiner’s tactical difficulty. Compositions 55 through 58 engage in some of the most literal obscurity *Please, Touch the Artwork* attempts, by outright removing any clear shapes from the composition. The neighboring color rule, an already somewhat tactically difficult mechanic due to its initially confusing potential effects, submerges into another layer of obfuscation. Any

previous ability to interpret the game space muddles significantly, leaving the now-hesitant player floating in a vacuous canvas.

“The Style”’s difficulty increases, then, through its abstraction and removal of conventional feedback; the game space is delineated and the player’s ability to extract clear meaning from their canvas takes a nosedive. But the systems and mechanics available to the player don’t change in the slightest, only the specificity of information does. This continues to parallel the curve of tactical difficulty in *Tender Buttons*. Just like the earlier compositions in “The Style”, *Tender Buttons*’ first section, “Objects” is significantly more defined than its expansive section, “Rooms”, despite both holding a consistent syntax and internal logic. “Rooms”’s overwhelming, singular description that stretches on for thirteen pages sits in stark contrast to the more concise statements of “Objects” that read like shorter poems. In “Objects”, smaller titles exist to bind every word present under it to that concept, no matter how abstract its description may be. Due to these distinct divisions paired with the smaller passages, it’s much easier to parse how the different words in *Tender Buttons* connect with one another. The divisions here, that are so helpful when dealing with Stein’s language, are lost in “Rooms”, in the same way the lines and concrete spaces are taken away at the end of “The Style”. The viewer can no longer define a clear “center” of relations between any two words or planes once these texts start to limit their feedback.

To leave the audience of a text so directionless is to force a very challenging predicament on them. In order to extract any sort of meaning from the gamespace or sentences, the viewer must “act” first, before interpreting. The general process of meaning-making in the MDA-GFI model places the stage of interpretation before the stage of mechanical action within a feedback loop. So, if there’s no feedback to interpret, or if the feedback is too abstract to take any literal

meaning from, the viewer has to make the decision to act and see how a text responds. A player of “The Style” knows how to engage with the canvas long before the final compositions’ delineation, in the same way a reader of *Tender Buttons* knows how to approach the language of “Rooms” from previous exposure to the shorter sections. Using this understanding to kick-start a feedback loop, they alone decide where to click, where to define, and where to experiment assigning significance. Certain parts of each text will then react to these decisions; colors will spill into unexpected, adjacent regions of the canvas and certain words will relate to and define each other differently. There is no “center” beyond the one the viewer creates through textual engagement, which is exactly why it's so useless: it's always relative to their focus, and their hand on the screen. To complicate interpretation in such a way demands that the audience define their own sense of relations in an abstract, insignificant space.

But what, ultimately, is the point of this abstraction and its difficulty if a text becomes so subjective and amorphous? Steiner believes that one of tactical difficulty’s defining strengths is its ability to “make new” of an overly familiar language (270). Turning a stale form on its head and revitalizing it is essential to the difficulty at play in *Tender Buttons* and “The Style”. Both seem to require the viewer to become aware of their own perceptual process whilst dealing with the challenges of abstraction. Akin to Shklovsky’s notion of estrangement, detailed in *Art, as Device*, these pieces both utilize a “complication of” their medium in order to “increase the duration and complexity of perception”, making the viewer recognize the importance of perception itself (162). The extent of their difficulty necessitates this since the viewer is forced to spend so much time making sense of limited feedback. They’re forced to think about how they’re thinking. By adding tactical difficulty and removing what permits a conventional engagement

with their form, both of these works bring attention to the process of how a viewer constructs and interprets their meaning.

The pseudo-English that *Tender Buttons* is written in makes the reader examine the way a more commonly-used English, and the definitions of words within it, naturally operates. In “Objects”, another sub-section titled “Objects” exists, that starts with, “Within, within” (Stein, 22). Within *Tender Buttons*, to help define itself and its ideas, is a section called “Objects”, and within that another, smaller work called “Objects”. This self-referential section functions like a joke about self-referential definitions, illustrating how the reuse of a word fails to describe itself. So, two layers deep in “Objects”, Stein states that “two in the center make two one side”; like the two identical titles, if a word describes itself it describes nothing (22). Two occurrences of the same word essentially flatten into one. A word isn’t a center, nor does it actually mean anything on its own. An “object” can’t be explained by just using the word “object” again, but it has to be contextualized through adjacent, and similar ideas. It's everything other than what it isn't. By attempting to have an object describe itself, *Tender Buttons* highlights how objects and words are only given meaning through relation. They’re just divisions between a spectrum of qualities: rooms with useless centers and useful windows. Through the abstraction of words and detachment from their literal meaning, the reader’s language is forcibly defamiliarized which allows the form of it to come more readily into focus.

Like this effect produced through the difficulty of *Tender Buttons*, “The Style” seems to thrive in its deviation from interactive norms. The lack of direct interaction with the game space and the tactical difficulty that comes from it effectively defamiliarizes players who attempt engagement. An article that repurposes Shklovsky’s ideas of estrangement for games describes these sorts of challenges as “poetic gameplay”. Poetic gameplay is a type of formal

experimentation that strives to achieve Shklovsky's sense of defamiliarization, where gameplay "is deliberately made strange" in order to draw "attention to the form of the work as a way to encourage reflection" (Mitchell et al.). "The Style"'s adjacent coloring mechanic fits within one of the article's categories of defamiliarization: "unfamiliar interface controls". These would be controls that purposefully defy convention and attempt to make the player carefully consider how they're interacting with the game space (Mitchell et al.). The way the player is only allowed to color in neighboring planes starts to suggest that interaction is more complex than a direct, input-response relationship.

When the blind feedback of Compositions 55 through 58 comes into play, the newly introduced tactical difficulty adds another kind of formal deviation to the equation: "imperfect information". Similarly to how lack of feedback creates interpretive/tactical difficulty, this poetic gameplay manifests through denying its players enough feedback to imagine how their actions will affect a gamestate (Mitchell et al.). The way in which imperfect information defamiliarizes players in "The Style", along with the game's already unfamiliar interface, suggests the idea that games are not something a player is in total control of. Rather, they're systems of relations and interactions that a player attempts to learn and express their will through. All they can do is act and hope that the dynamics of the system, with enough experience, might carry them to a desired win state. There's still player agency, but the fantasy of complete control over a system, even one that isn't randomized, is revealed to be an illusion of interactivity.

With this defamiliarizing tactical difficulty, these texts begin to reveal some sort of truth about their respective forms. *Tender Buttons* works to expose the reader to the inherently relational construct of language, and "The Style" flaunts the idea of direct player control in an interactive system; these feats are accomplished through the removal of direct access to a text's

supposed content. Expression in both cases is seen to be a volatile subject, since clear communication is revealed missing from the source code of any language, written or ludic. Words are relational constructs that disguise themselves as “centers” of information, and any kind of interface never allows for a one-to-one interaction, even if an on-screen hand seems to imply it. In order for one to act with lucidity, there should be an understanding that there is no center, and no direct path for expression on either the receiving or sending ends of communication. But both of these texts also prove that communication through a system is not impossible given enough time, experimentation, and will. Despite an abstract nature, one can still engage with either text so long as they’re comfortable acting with an unstable interpretation; they have to be comfortable acting without a center.

But this destabilization of familiar forms and, potentially, perception itself quickly becomes its own kind of challenge. How does one deal with an idea that’s so utterly estranged from their usual means of understanding? Steiner’s last and most open-ended category of difficulty, ontological difficulty, seems built to examine these exact ideas:

Ontological difficulties confront us with blank questions about the nature of human speech, about the status of significance, about the necessity and purpose of the construct which we have, with more or less rough and ready consensus, come to perceive as a poem. (Steiner, 273)

When a reader or player comes into contact with a tactically difficult text, specifically one that resists their typical route to engagement with it, these confusions are bound to sprout. The ontological challenge that can manifest in tactical difficulty is naturally disorienting since Steiner admits that it can’t be resolved easily (273). We, as viewers of ontological difficulty, are left to grapple with the strangeness of language, communication and agency. When formally resistant

texts like *Tender Buttons* and *Please, Touch the Artwork* bring their own structures into question, it becomes harder to hold a solid sense of them, and even reality, since they force us to question how we perceive it. But this seemingly foreign ontological difficulty shouldn't necessarily have to resolve itself. As Shklovsky puts it, estrangement makes "a stone stony" and the challenges that arise from these texts likely refresh our understanding of interpretation (162). To consider our meaning-making processes as center-less is a reasonable way to think of them; they likely *make* meaning from a blank canvas that we blindly trust ourselves to color in correctly. It feels invaluable, then, that texts like these can make us question that blind faith.

Works Cited

- Cardona-rivera, Rogelio E., et al. "GFI: A Formal Approach to Narrative Design and Game Research." *International Conference on Interactive Digital Storytelling*, 2020, pp. 133-48. *ResearchGate*, https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-62516-0_13.
- Jagoda, Patrick. "On Difficulty in Video Games: Mechanics, Interpretation, Affect." *Critical Inquiry*, vol. 45, no. 1, Sept. 2018, pp. 199-233. *The University of Chicago Press Journals*, <https://doi.org/10.1086/699585>.
- Mitchell, Alex, et al. "A Preliminary Categorization of Techniques for Creating Poetic Gameplay." *The International Journal of Computer Game Research*, vol. 20, no. 2, June 2020. *DiGRA*, gamestudies.org/2002/articles/mitchell_kway_neo_sim. Accessed 3 May 2023.
- Shklovsky, Viktor. "Art, as Device." *Poetics Today*, vol. 36, no. 3, 1 Sept. 2015, pp. 151-74. *Duke University Press*, <https://doi.org/10.1215/03335372-3160709>.
- Stein, Gertrude, and Seth Perlow. *Tender Buttons*. San Francisco, City Lights Books, 2014.
- Steiner, George. "On Difficulty." *The Journal of Aesthetics and Art Criticism*, vol. 36, no. 3, 1978, p. 263. *JSTOR*, <https://doi.org/10.2307/430437>.
- Waterzooi, Thomas. *Please, Touch the Artwork*. [PC/Switch/Android/iOS]. Studio Waterzooi, 2020.